



The End of the 'Energy Drink' Label in India

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So, what do you mean by energy drink ? Obvious, anyone will say that it's a drink that boosts physical energy and mental focus. But have you ever wondered is it actually true ? It has been clearly stated by FSSAI that there is no term like energy drink , and it is **not a legally recognised food category** under Indian food laws.

So why then all these global brands are selling drinks under the term of energy drink? It all falls down to two things money and psychology marketing.

So first let me tell you which brands sell energy drinks:

1. Red Bull
2. Campa
3. Sting
4. Monster
5. Hell (the name itself suggest you shouldn't drink)
6. Adrenaline Rush

3 Core Reasons:

1. Premium Pricing Power: If Red Bull positioned itself as just a "caffeinated soft drink," consumers would compare its price directly to a regular can of Coca-Cola or Pepsi. By inventing and using the term "**Energy Drink**," they created an entirely new premium category. This allowed them to charge **3x to 5x more**. People willingly pay a premium for "energy," but they won't pay it for ordinary soda.
2. Selling a Psychological "Feeling," Not Just a Product: The term "energy" triggers an immediate emotional and functional response in the consumer's brain. Scientifically, caffeine does not give your body actual caloric energy. It simply blocks the brain chemicals that make you feel tired, creating an *illusion* of wakefulness. Calling it an "Energy Drink" makes it sound like a **performance-enhancing superpower** for students pulling night shifts, athletes, and gamers. *We need to understand that energy drinks are different from sport drinks : Sports drinks are designed to rehydrate the body and replenish electrolytes lost through sweat during exercise, whereas energy drinks rely on stimulants to provide a temporary mental and physical surge.*
3. Historical Legacy (How it Started): The term has a deep-rooted global history. In 1984, Austrian businessman Dietrich Mateschitz discovered an energising tonic called [Krating](#).

[Daeng](#) in Thailand (which translated to Red Bull) and he launched it in Europe. New entrants like **Sting** and Reliance's **Campa Energy** simply adopted the term because the multi-billion-dollar market layout was already built around it.

Thus, the FSSAI rejected industry appeals to stretch the rebranding timeline to a year, maintaining the strict 90-day compliance window. Local governments are actively restricting access for children. For example, the [Maharashtra FDA banned the sale of these beverages](#) within a 500-metre radius of schools to prevent caffeine overload in students.

State authorities, notably in Rajasthan, have already seized hundreds of thousands of cans. Platforms like **Amazon**, **Flipkart**, **Blinkit**, and **Swiggy Instamart** have been ordered to stop promoting or categorizing these items as "energy drinks". Additionally, companies must stop using unproven health claims like "*vitalizes body and mind*" or "*enhances focus*".

*The FSSAI defines caffeinated beverages products by their chemical thresholds: 1. They should be strictly classified as flavored, water-based drinks (which can be carbonated or non-carbonated). 2. They must contain caffeine at a concentration **higher than 145 mg per litre but no more than 300 mg per litre**. 3. "**High Caffeine**" declaration. They must also explicitly state on the package that consumers should not drink more than 500 ml (approx. two cans) per day.*

Also important to note that **sting energy drink** was never meant for children to drink, (as listed on the packaging), but the major consumer market for this drink were children. There were many targeted brands on which FSSAI issued notices for misleading claims and packaging terminology. All this happened from June to August.